



Mohandas Gandhi lies in state after his assassination by a Hindu fanatic who blamed him for the partition of India.

THE CROWNING ACHIEVEMENT OF MOHANDAS GANDHI

(b. 1868) was realized when **India won independence** in 1947. However, the concessions he made to Muslims led to his assassination by a **Hindu fanatic** who blamed him for the partition of India, even though Gandhi had bitterly opposed the splitting up of the subcontinent. The news of **Gandhi's assassination** had a profound effect throughout the world, and a state of mourning was declared in India.

South Africa held May elections that saw the **National Party** take power from Jan Smuts' United Party. **Dr D. F. Malan** (1874–1959) became prime minister and formed the first government dominated by **Afrikaners**. Immediately after the election, the government began institutionalizing **segregation**. Malan believed that Africans threatened the prosperity and purity of the Afrikaner culture.

He based his policy on a system that became known as **apartheid** and enforced a racial hierarchy privileging white South Africans (see 1994).

Anticolonial sentiment grew in the **Malay Peninsula** after World War II. Groups of guerrillas took to the jungle, led by communist fanatic **Chin Peng** (b. 1924). In February, there were terrorist attacks on European settlers, and later an "emergency" was declared.

All-Korean elections had been called for in 1948, but **Kim Il Sung** (1912–94), the leader of North Korea, persuaded the **Soviets** not to allow the UN north of the **38th parallel** (the boundary between the northern zone of the Korean Peninsula, occupied by the USSR, and the southern zone, controlled by US forces), believing he could not possibly win a free election. As a result, a month after the South was granted independence as the **Republic of Korea**, on August 15, the **Democratic People's Republic of Korea** (DPRK) was proclaimed, with Kim as premier. On October 12, the Soviet Union declared Kim's regime the only lawful government on the peninsula. By 1949, **North Korea** was a full-fledged **communist dictatorship**.

The UN had devised a plan to split **Palestine** into Jewish and Arab nations, but it was not adhered to when the **state of Israel** was proclaimed by its first prime minister, **David Ben-Gurion**, on May 14. The last British troops withdrew on

UN PARTITION PLAN 1947



Plan for Palestine

The UN General Assembly proposed to split Palestine into Jewish and Arab states, with Jerusalem under international administration.

May 15. Five **Arab armies** from Jordan, Egypt, Syria, Lebanon, and Iraq immediately invaded the new Jewish state but were repulsed. The Israeli army crushed pockets of resistance and extended its borders in what became known as the **first Arab-Israeli War** (see 1949). The realization that the Israeli nation might survive increased anti-Israeli and anti-Jewish sentiment throughout the Arab world.

The **Organization of American States** (OAS) came into being on April 30. Its members were

the independent states of North and South America. They pledged to **fight communism**, increase security, and aid economic growth.

Harry Truman (1884–1972) had steered the US through the end of World War II and the beginning of the Cold War. However, he was not expected to win the **1948 presidential election** against the Republican Thomas E. Dewey, due to his pro-Civil Rights policies, which had alienated many southern Democrats. As the campaign continued, he won the following of the people and was reelected in one of the biggest **election upsets** in history.

In **Britain**, the debate over free healthcare had been ongoing since the 19th century. After Labour's election victory in 1945, **Aneurin Bevan** (1897–1960) presented a plan to provide free healthcare to all for the first time. Bevan formally launched

the **National Health Service** (NHS) on July 5.

With World War II over, the Olympic committee (IOC) could once again select a nation to host the **Olympic Games**. London was chosen, but six years of war had left Britain with shortages of food and clothing, and the 1948 celebrations became known as the "**Austerity Games**." These Olympics saw the **first defection** from the communist East to the West when the head of the Czechoslovakian gymnastics team, **Marie Provaznikova**, refused to return home.

Czechoslovakia had been moving toward democracy after World War II, but the Soviets did not intend to allow any state within their sphere of influence to become a democracy. **Communists**, supported by the Soviets, carried out a **coup in Prague**, in February. The Czech president, **Edvard Beneš** (1884–1948), was removed from



Segregation sign

Under **apartheid**, separate residency areas were created, and social contact between different races was strictly prohibited.

DAVID BEN-GURION (1886–1973)

The founder of the state of Israel, Ben-Gurion was born in Poland and immigrated to Palestine in 1906. He became an active supporter of the struggle for an independent Jewish state and was expelled from Palestine in 1915 due to his nationalist activities. During World War II, he helped Jews fleeing from the Nazi Holocaust. Ben-Gurion retired from politics in 1970.

